“NOYO - CREATING YOUR EXPERIENCE”
A case study on the creation of affective brand script and visual product identity

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Case paper

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Abstract

Visual recognition and emotional contents of product design are increasingly relevant topics with respect to brand management. Within the brand creation process, various symbolic qualities and emotional aspects can be developed around the functional product to create a strong and affective story, or “script”, for the brand. When creating such brand script, it is particularly important to ensure that different communication media are consistently utilised. In specific, the semantic contents of product design need to be aligned with the brand’s core values, so that the design features and characteristics communicate the true essence of the brand. This case paper explores the key aspects of creating an affective and believable story for a brand and expressing it through design. This is illustrated through a student project that was organised in the Chalmers University of Technology in the Autumn of 2005. The paper aims to show how the processes of market analysis, brand creation, and semantic reference building in design could be structured. The Noyo case highlights the importance of holistic approach towards creating affective brands and products. In addition to an excellent product, technically, cognitively and emotionally, appealing story is needed around it and the brand it represents. The key challenge then concerns the transformation of this essence into the visual and other product attributes and, finally, into an emotional presentation of the concept.

Key words

Brands, product design, recognition, visual identity, product identity

1. Introduction

Visual recognition and emotional contents of product design are becoming increasingly relevant topics with respect to brand creation and management in many product fields. Visual recognition of a branded product takes place both through explicit design cues and through merely implicit associations related to the overall reputation, image and appreciation of the brand and its products. Within the brand creation process, various symbolic qualities and emotional aspects can be developed around the functional product to create a strong and affective story, or "script", for the brand. Through such a story, the users may experience the product more appealing and, consequently, also feel more attached to the brand. When creating the brand script, it is particularly important to ensure that the various communication media are utilised consistently to tell the same story. With regard to products, the semantic contents of product design need to be aligned with the brand's core values, so that the design features and characteristics communicate the true essence of the brand. When consistently used, product design is a powerful media of strategic brand communication and recognition building, for which various approaches and frameworks occur (see e.g. Warell 2001, Karjalainen 2004).

2. Project on visual brand and product identity

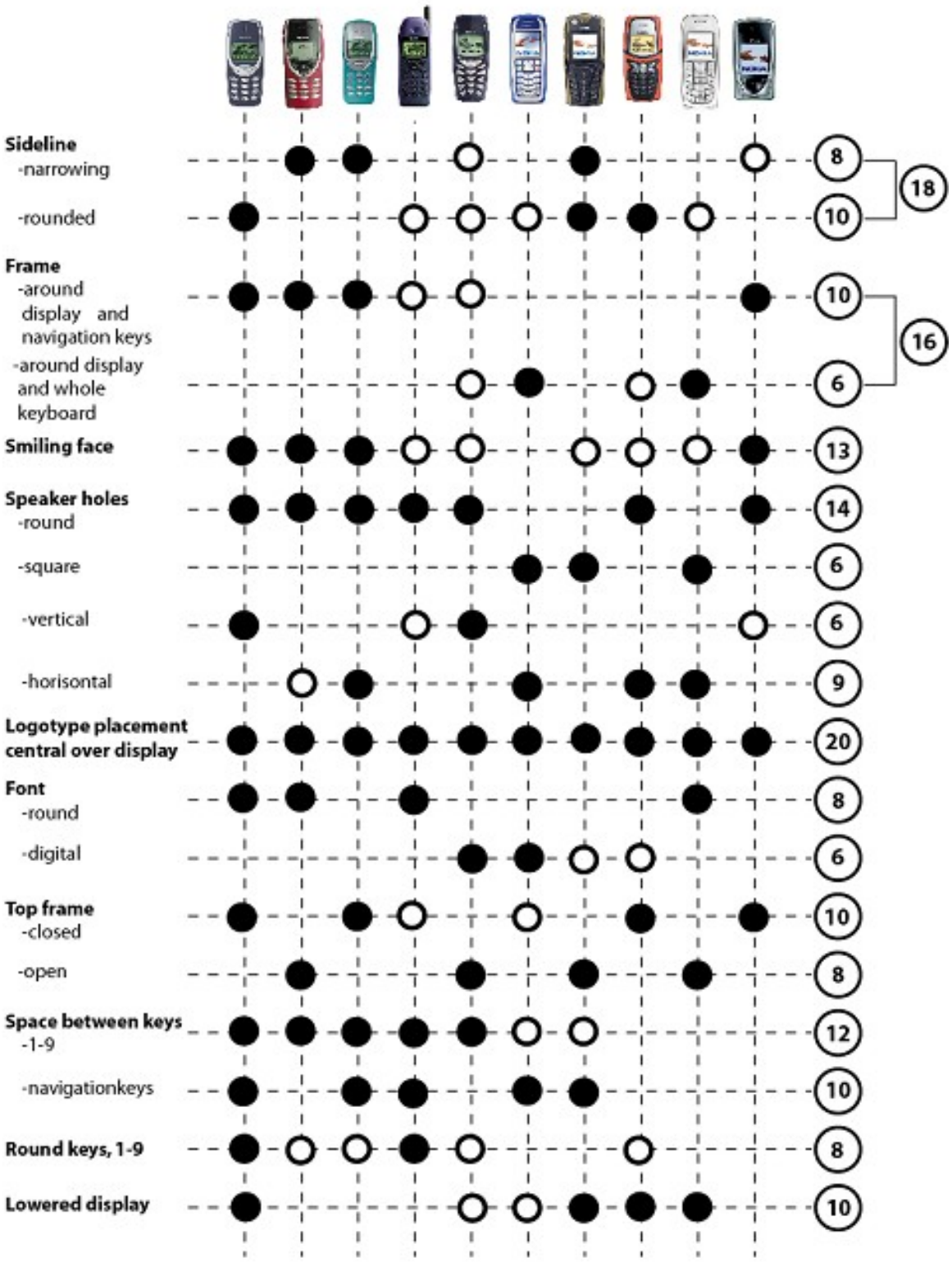
What are then the key aspects of creating an affective and believable story for a brand and expressing it through design? The fundamental concern is to be able to define and describe the essence of the brand, what it truly stands for and how it is differentiated from competitors. Then, of course, the visual identity of the brand's products and other media of communication should be aligned with this essence. Furthermore, the whole package should be presented for various stakeholders in emotionally convincing and appealing manner. In this paper, some insights are given into this multifaceted and, more than anything, creative process of creating brands and products that have potential to surprise and delight. The process is discussed through the case of the "Noyo" brand. The creation of Noyo was executed as a Master-level student design project, organised between October and December 2005 in the Chalmers University of Technology, Gothenburg, Sweden. The project was a part of the "Visual brand identity and market analysis" course, organized annually within the International Master's Programs in Automotive Industrial Design Engineering (for description of the 2004 project, see Karjalainen & Warell 2005) and Industrial Design Engineering.

In the 2005 project, altogether 13 teams of 2-3 design students performed profound analyses of two brands: one car brand and one other brand, all selected from the Interbrand's list of the World's 100 strongest brands. The focus was on defining the basis of brand identity (e.g. core values, positioning, target customers) and the visual product identity of these brands, using provided methods such as design format analysis. Many groups also developed their own creative methods for visual analyses. In the second assignment, students designed a fictive dashboard or a larger concept of a car interior, incorporating selected values of the original brands and respective aspects of visual recognition. Instead of explicitly transforming the design cues of the original brands to the new product, students were encouraged to develop a totally new brand with its underlying story. Emphasis was also put on the presentation of new brands and products in an emotionally appealing manner.

To illustrate the process, an exemplary group work of three students (Ida Ljungman, Karin Lodin and Karolina Starodub) is presented in this paper. This group analysed the identities of Toyota and Nokia and created the Noyo brand on this ground. This description is only a short version of the project but aims to show how the process was managed and to highlight the key issues of creating affective brands and products.

3. Digging into the brand essence

First, the brand images of Nokia and Toyota were carefully analysed. The analysis consisted of four parts: brand research, customer and retailer study, expert analysis, and design format analysis. Design format analysis (see figure 1) was used to ensure an objective view into the product analysis.


Sideline
-narrowing
-rounded
Frame
-around display and navigation keys
-around display and whole keyboard
Smiling face
Speaker holes
-round
-square
-vertical
-horisontal
Logotype placement central over display
Font
-round
-digital
Top frame
-closed
-open
Space between keys
-1-9
-navigationkeys
Round keys, 1-9
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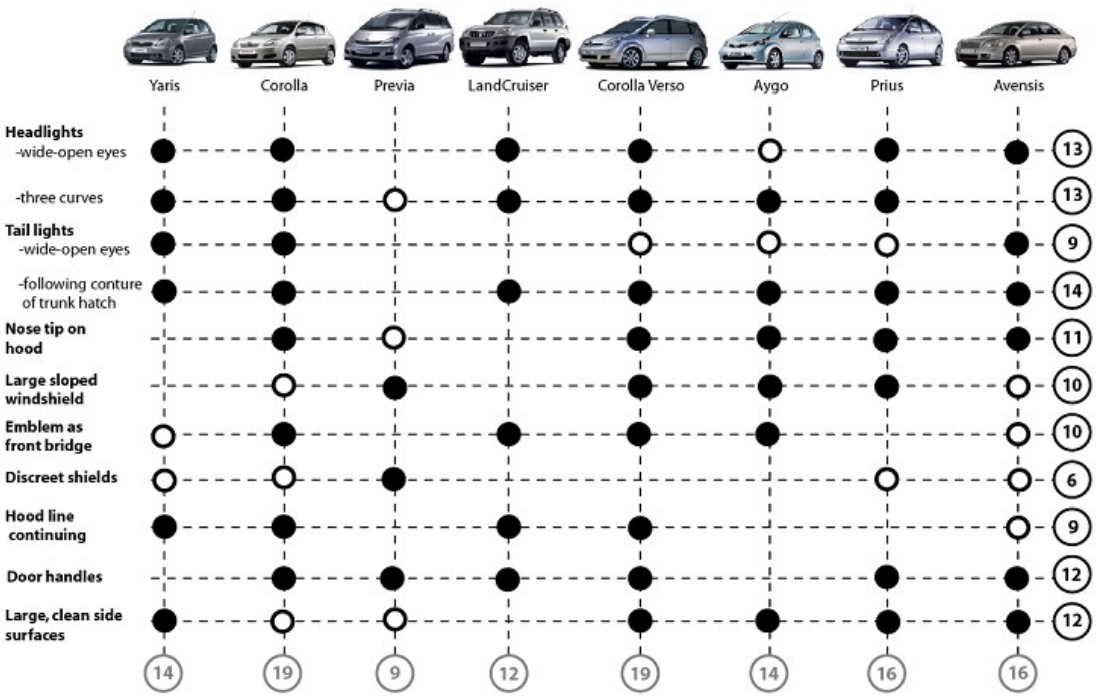


Figure 1, Examples of Nokia and Toyota design format analyses

The most interesting part of this phase, the expert analysis, was conducted through a workshop (with design students) in which blind tests (see figure 2), recognition tests (see figure 3) and other methods were utilised to address questions such as: *What is typical for Nokia's/Toyotas design? What is typical for the brand in general? What does the brand stand for? What are the advantages of buying a Nokia mobile phone/Toyota car? What are the weaknesses of Nokia/Toyota brands?*



Figure 2, Examples of products used in the mobile phone blind test in which cues for visual recognition were explored

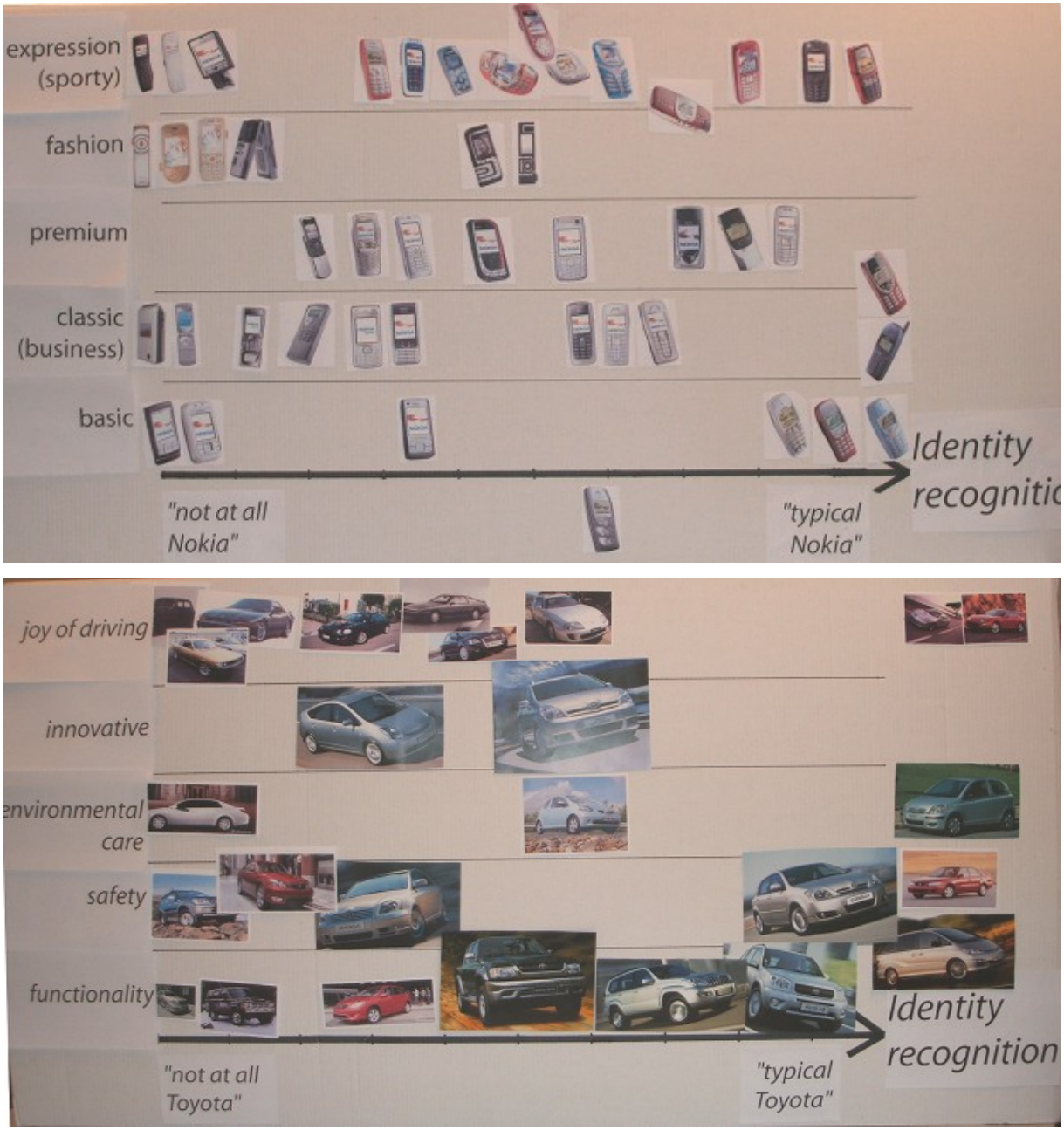


Figure 3, Examples of Nokia and Toyota recognition tests in which brand typicality and category recognition were assessed (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

When analysing Toyota and Nokia, it became clear that both brand have strong identities with regard to qualitative characteristics and core values. Some explicit design cues were also found in both cases, even though they were not consistently used over the entire product portfolios of the companies. Both Nokia and Toyota have a wide variety of different models, designed for different customer segments, which results in a seemingly low visual consistency.

The challenging task was to find the true essence of both brands. The new brand was built on the foundations of the Nokia and Toyota, but additional values were also incorporated to sharpen the definition and perception of Nokia and Toyota brands. Through the analysis, many aspects were found that were common for both brands. They are next briefly described.

Both brands communicate *reliability* as one of their strengths. Through a more distinct contemplation, it was revealed that, in the Nokia case, reliability stands for quality and usability. Moreover, the Nokia slogan, "Connecting people", holds a reliability dimension by suggesting that the company is selling more than only mobile phones, namely the service of connecting people, which, furthermore, makes the customer conceive the products and services reliable. In the Toyota, the topic of free ownership, where customers don't have to worry about technical problems, was often addressed. Toyota's maintenance services have a good reputation in Sweden, providing customers with smooth and fast reparations and additional services in a short time. Consequently, it was derived from this that the real essence of reliability actually refers to "caring", for both Nokia and Toyota. Caring says a lot more about what the brands stand for than reliability that could easily be understood as "functionality" in a technical sense. Both Nokia and Toyota are focusing on the human side of the products, not only on the technology.

"Connecting people" has also a *bridge building* dimension, something that is strongly apparent in both brands, but that only Nokia is explicitly expressing. Since both Nokia and Toyota are world leading brands and "peoples' brands" that many people could like and afford, they may stand for something that is uniting people and building bridges between cultures. The products of Nokia and Toyota, mobile phones and cars, are also bridge building and connecting, since they enable people to connect and meet.

Each customer of Nokia and Toyota is regarded as unique and having his or her own *personality*. To satisfy every person, both brands offer a large variety of products. Nokia also has a strong tradition of creating personalised products. For instance, it introduced changeable covers in the early mobile phone models. To be able to compete on the market and to maintain leading position in technology, it is also important to be *innovative*. In the Nokia and Toyota case, innovation is fundamentally about creating new services and a richness of products, as well as using existing technology in new ways.

The *heritage* of Nokia or Toyota, referring to the cultural backgrounds of the companies, is not explicitly carried through the product design. The customers and the experts that were interviewed, however, strongly perceive the brands as Japanese and Finnish. This aspect could somehow show in product design, since it has strong emotional and recognition value.

One problem that became obvious through the analysis was the *lack of desirability* in both Nokia and Toyotas products. The respondents did not express any "must have"-feelings during the interviews or the expert workshop. Impressions were rather the opposite. Apple-computers and MP3-players were regarded as examples of products with a high desirability-factor. Desirability-factor, in general, refers to the feelings of "want to have", "want to touch" and "want to feel". Desirability is also sometimes described as something luxurious, as in the case of jewellery and other exclusive products, which may not imply to the case of Toyota and Nokia. Through further discussions and analyses, it was realised that desirability actually has a caring-dimension, which was emphasised when creating the new brand. Products that signal deep devotion to the needs of customers are products that attract them. In the project it was thus found that the word *caring* has many different dimensions.

4. "Noyo" - Creating the new brand

In the second part of the project, the goal was to create a new brand that, to some degree, merged together the Nokia and Toyota identities and, consequently, to develop a product representing this new brand.

4.1 Brand name and logotype

An important part of building the brand is to create a relevant and affective brand name and logotype. In this case, a name and logo was searched that would be new but, at the same time, recognisable and easy for everyone to pronounce. Moreover, the sound of the name should not be aggressive. The name Noyo came from the brand name **No**kia and To**yo**ta, but it also stands for something new – *neue* (German) or *nuevo* (Spanish). The name also connects to Japanese and Finnish languages – it is supposed to sound like a Finnish word pronounced with a Japanese accent.

4.2 The brand concept

It was then analysed, how Noyo should be positioned. Based on the positions of Nokia and Toyota, the goal was to further increase the feeling of personality, friendliness and innovativeness to make the new brand more distinctive and desirable (see figure 4).

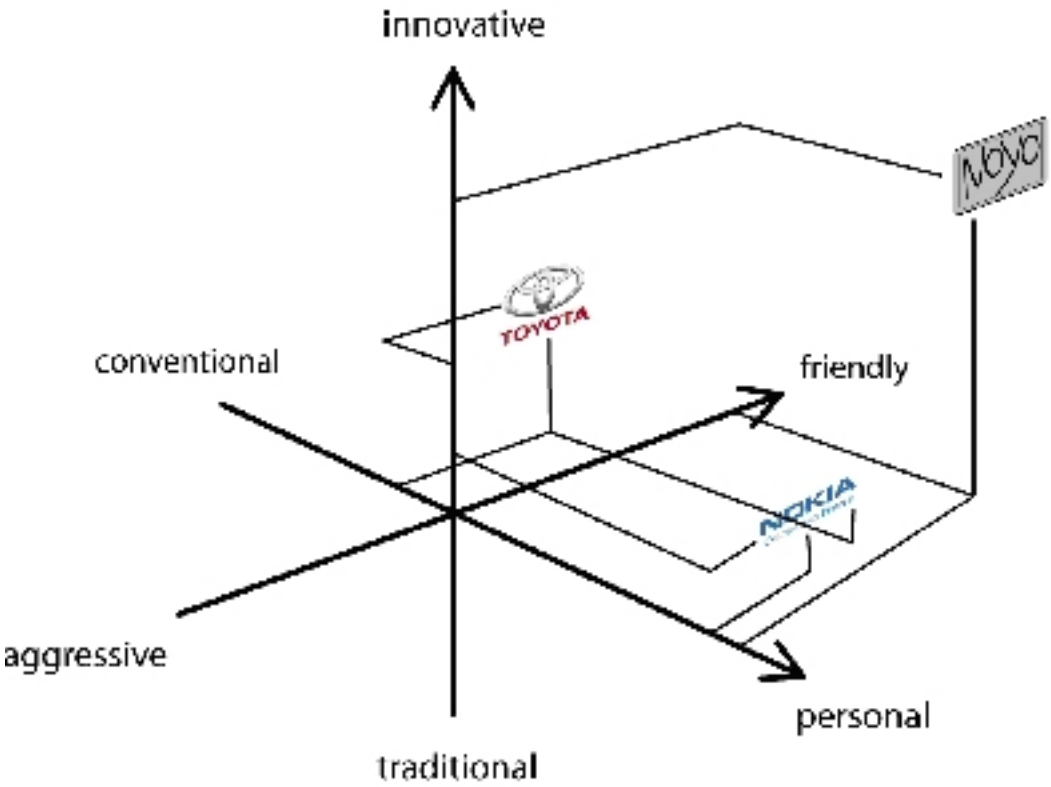


Figure 4, Brand positions of Nokia, Toyota, and Noyo (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

It was also contemplated to whom the brand is directed. What is the target group of Noyo? It was concluded that Noyo should serve a very wide group of customers, since Noyo is providing a series of different products and services. Like Toyota and Nokia, Noyo should be a "people's brand" that most people can afford. With regard to the core products and services, the decision was made accordingly that Noyo is a worldwide communication company that offers a variety of products and services for both consumers and companies.

4.3 Noyo core values

The next important step was to decide the core values of the brand: These were developed from the brand essence analysis of Nokia and Toyota. As a tool of group communication, lots

of pictures were also used in this phase. By creating inspiration boards for each core value, the fundamental feeling of the new brand was created (see figure 5).

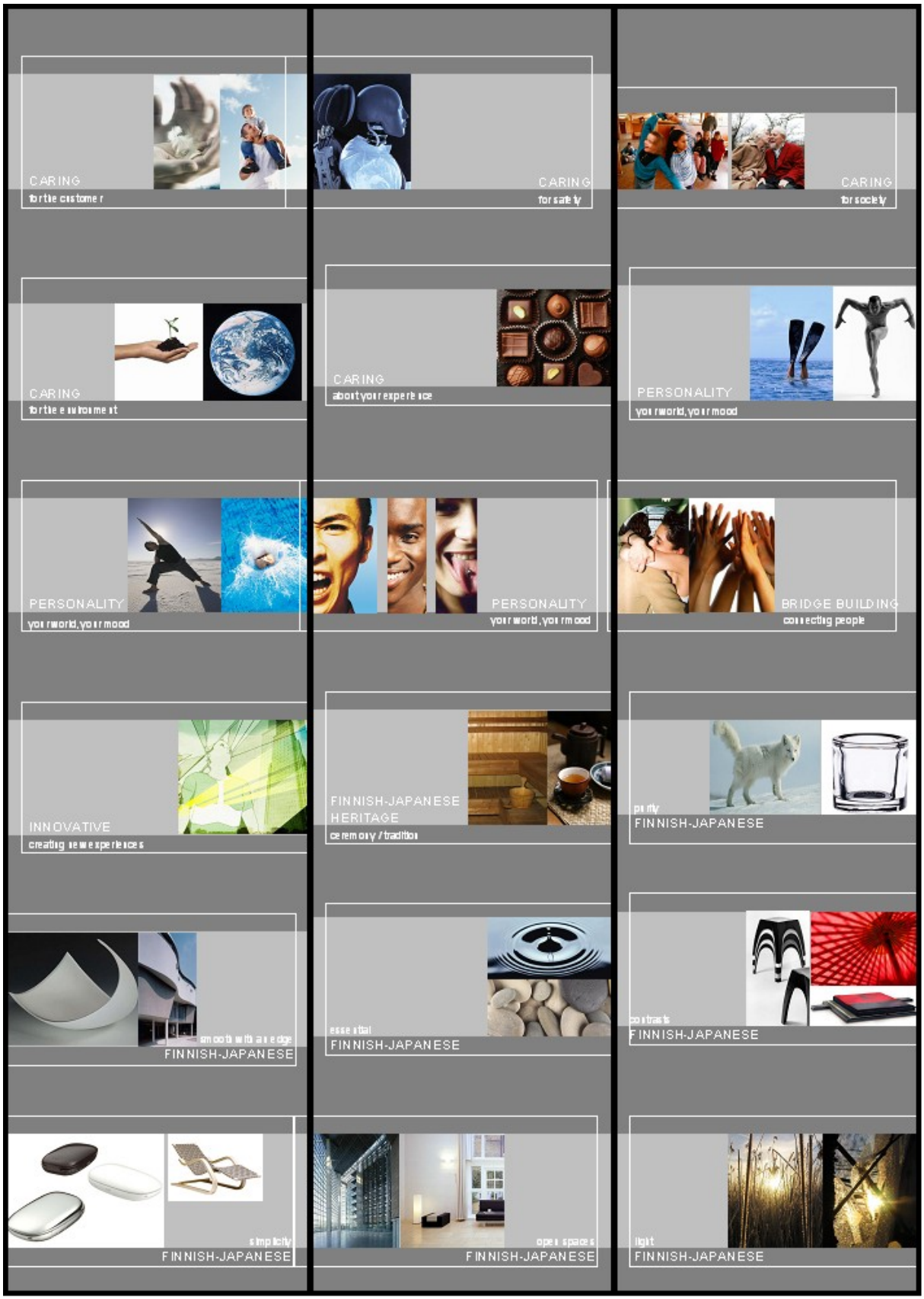


Figure 5, Noyo inspiration boards (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

These boards also grounded the visual design philosophy of the brand that is further discussed in the next chapter. Noyo incorporates five core values:

Caring

- ...for the Customer**:** Noyo promises to take a professional care of the customers and fulfil all their needs.
- …for Safety (active safety): Physical care for the customer.
- …for the Society: Investments in education in schools and universities, donation, charity.
- …for the Environment: Working for decreasing air pollutions, recycling of products, minimal material waste.
- …about customer experiences / desirability: Noyo wants to create a perfect use experience.

Personality

- Noyo helps its customers to create their personal worlds. Therefore, customers' moods and desires are the starting point for the development of new Noyo products and services.

Finnish-Japanese heritage

- Noyo wants to show from were it is originating: It is grounded on two leading global brands from two distinct parts of the world.
- The Japanese design philosophy is about respect for private space. It is dominated by harmony and simplicity, which gives a resting place from the frantic culture of the industrial world outside. Other cultural values of Japan include balance, functionality and durability.
- Finnish design is simple, organic, clean, sturdy, and functional.
- Despite the long geographical and cultural distance between these two countries, there are a lot of similarities with regards to design, particularly the focus on essential materials and the simplicity.
- Both cultures incorporate strong ceremonies: serving tea in Japan and going to the sauna in Finland. These may seam very different on the surface, but the core meaning

is to live out an experience and share it with other people. This reinforces the "caring" heritage that is central for Noyo.

- The Japanese and the Finnish heritage may be summarised as referring to *purity, smooth with an edge, essential, ceremony, simplicity, open spaces, lights and contrasts.*

Building bridges - connecting people

- Noyo is building bridges between cultures, countries, branches, and people. The aim is to encourage people to foster contacts with their friends and families. In fact, Noyo is going even further, "beyond the borders", creating global communication by bringing people from different cultures together.
- Consequently, Noyo has products and services in different price categories, but the basic range of models in different parts of the world is always the same.

Innovation

- Noyo's aim is not only to build the bridges between people all over the world, but to find new ways of doing it. The company wants to create new experiences for customers by using existing technologies and knowledge in new and exiting ways. The most important goal is to satisfy the present needs of customers, predict their future desires and even go further by creating desires that people do not yet know that they have.

5. Creating the script - brand history and philosophy

To add more affective aspects into the brand, a more holistic story was created for the brand. This script consisted of a formulation of the history, philosophy, and visual design philosophy of the Noyo brand.

5.1 Noyo history

Through a method called "back-casting", the group imagined Noyo in the year of 2020. From this year, it was looked back how the new brand had developed since its establishment in 2005. What have been important milestones in the brand's history and how does it look upon the future? In the following summary, a fictive story of the Noyo brand is described.

Year 2005

Toyota and Nokia decided to build a new brand together. The reason for this was the possibility of creating complex communication system, services and products. Both Nokia and Toyota were leading companies in their branches. With the new brand Noyo, they wanted to create communication systems without limits. Both Nokia and Toyota have a soul that is much more than just the products they manufacture, and in 2005 they realised that they share many values. They have similar aims of bringing people together and make them communicate. Noyo was created on this ground. Customised services and products were planned to offer customers a perfect personal experience.

Year 2010

Noyo introduced their first products into the world market. The Noyo World Foundation, an organisation focusing on environmental care, human health, and economical assistance to the developing countries, was also established. Noyo was marketing itself as the brand that puts the customer in focus, fostering the personal experience in every interaction with Noyo's products and services.

Year 2020

Noyo is the leading brand when it comes to commitment to developing measures against global warming and air pollution. "The Noyo family" is generally used to designate the Noyo customer base, consisting of a broad range of modern, open-minded people. The first Noyo schools were also founded this year.

5.2. Noyo brand philosophy

A brand philosophy was also created for Noyo. This comprises, in a nutshell, the following key issues:

- Noyo is selling a whole concept with products and services, rather than specific products. The customers experience is in specific focus. With Noyo, the life should get easier and more pleasant. Noyo wants to build up an intimate relationship built on trust and respect through professionalism and caring.
- Noyo cares about the environment and society. It takes responsibility in creating a better world for everybody. It is a world bridge builder that connects people, societies and cultures. Through the charity foundation, Noyo helps people all over the world make their dreams and hopes come true.

- Noyo cares about the Finnish and Japanese heritage. Inspiration is drawn from the pure and genuine aspects of the Finnish and Japanese cultures.
- The general impression of Noyo should be: The company that provides professional services and perfect experiences through honest product design.

5.3 Noyo visual design philosophy

The philosophy of Noyo brand and products not only concerns being perceived by reputation and reliability but also by providing excitement and consistency through design. Using specific design cues, surface finishes, and technical solutions, the core values and the identity of the brand should be recognized and visible in the product. The aim is to create dynamic appearance - so that simple lines and clear surfaces meet in the dynamic and fun appearance. Noyo design language is constructed through the Japanese and Finnish heritage. The main aspects of the Noyo design philosophy are:

- Colours: Contrasting colours (White-black, red-black, relating to the Japanese heritage), Natural colours (white-black-grey-blue)
- Materials: Glass, concrete, ceramics
- Light: Use of light to create certain personal mood, changeable lighting
- Form language: Smooth lines and surfaces with an edge, "second skin" – create a feeling of that the product is a part of the customer, friendly form language rather than aggressive.

6. Realising the script - the Noyo design process

Next, a product for Noyo was created. The product that was developed was a car interior, "Noyo Inside". The group still imagined themselves being in the year of 2020. In the product design this resulted in a decreased number of limitations in design with regard to possible technologies. The aim was to vision how a Noyo product would look like. This "Noyo Inside" product can be applied in many different car brands, creating the user's own environment in any type of car. This product, in particular, is meant to be a leading model of the brand, a product of desire.

6.1 Target customer

In defining the target customer of the product, a tool called social diagram (source: Sinus Sociovision GmbH, http://www.sinus-sociovision.de/) was used. The target customer for the

specific product that was developed in this project is presented in figure 6. It may be described as consisting of upper/middle class of modernistic and open-minded people. More specifically, such customer would be 30-35 years old, metropolitan, successful and creative, having multiple identities, interested in innovations, eager to try new things, aware of quality, authenticity and environmental care, not in the need of status symbols, and considering self-realisation and own identity important.

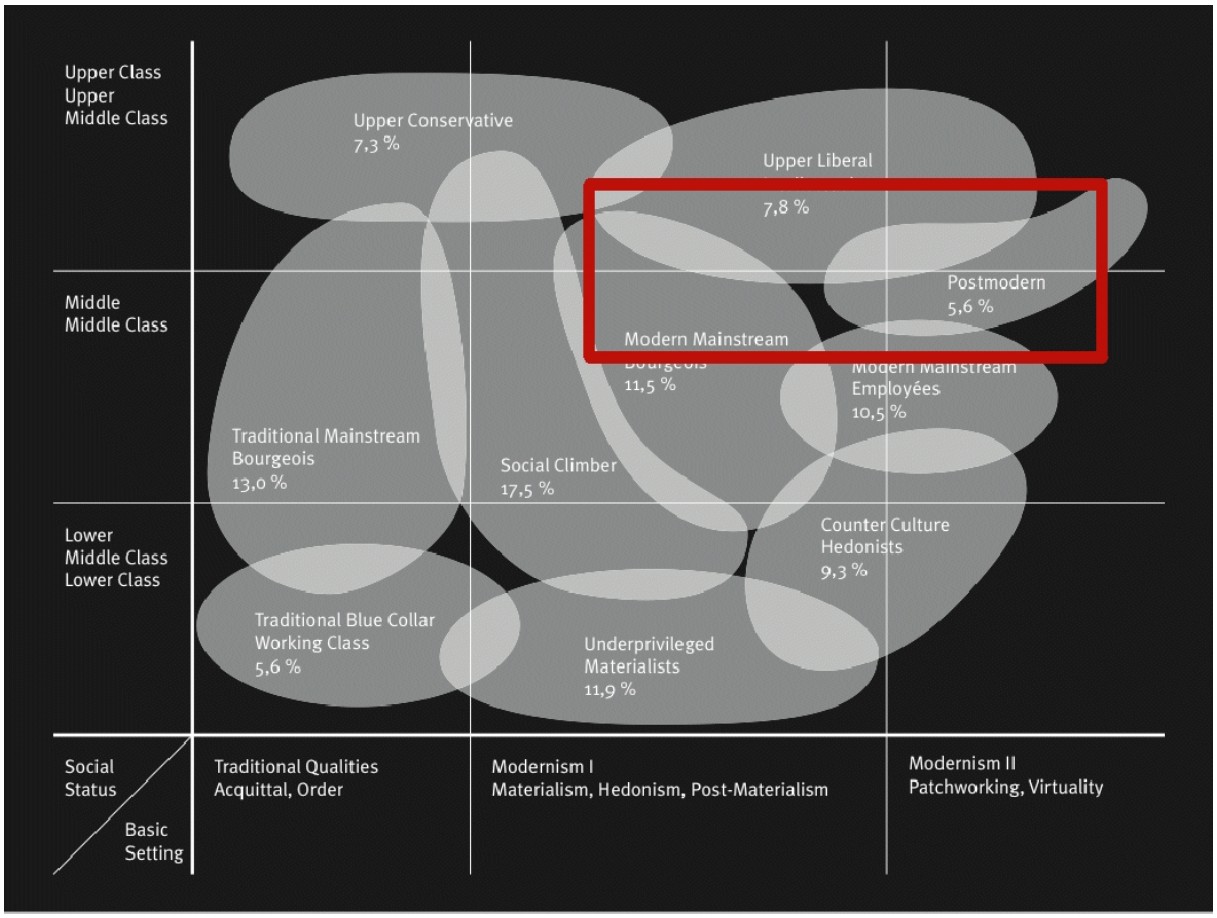
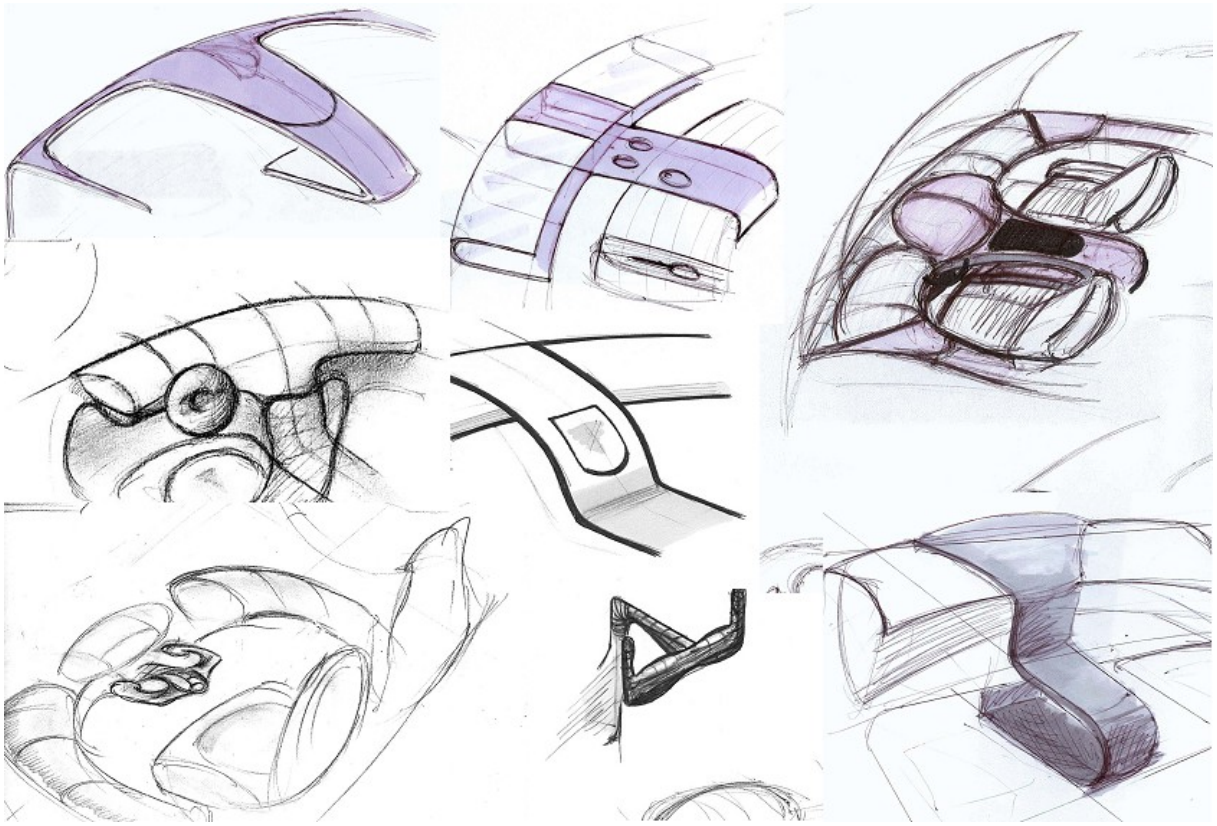


Figure 6, The target customer of Noyo product placed in the social diagram (Copyright by Sinus Sociovision GmbH, http://www.sinus-sociovision.de/)

6.2 Sketching phase

With the material that verbally and visually defined the brand, such as the inspiration boards, design philosophy, and description of the target user, a sketching session was conducted. With a sketching strategy consisting of both individual work and group sketching, a large variety of ideas were produced (see figure 7). The evaluation of the ideas were based on the brand platform and the target user definition and the concepts were reduced one by one, until there was the final basic design left.





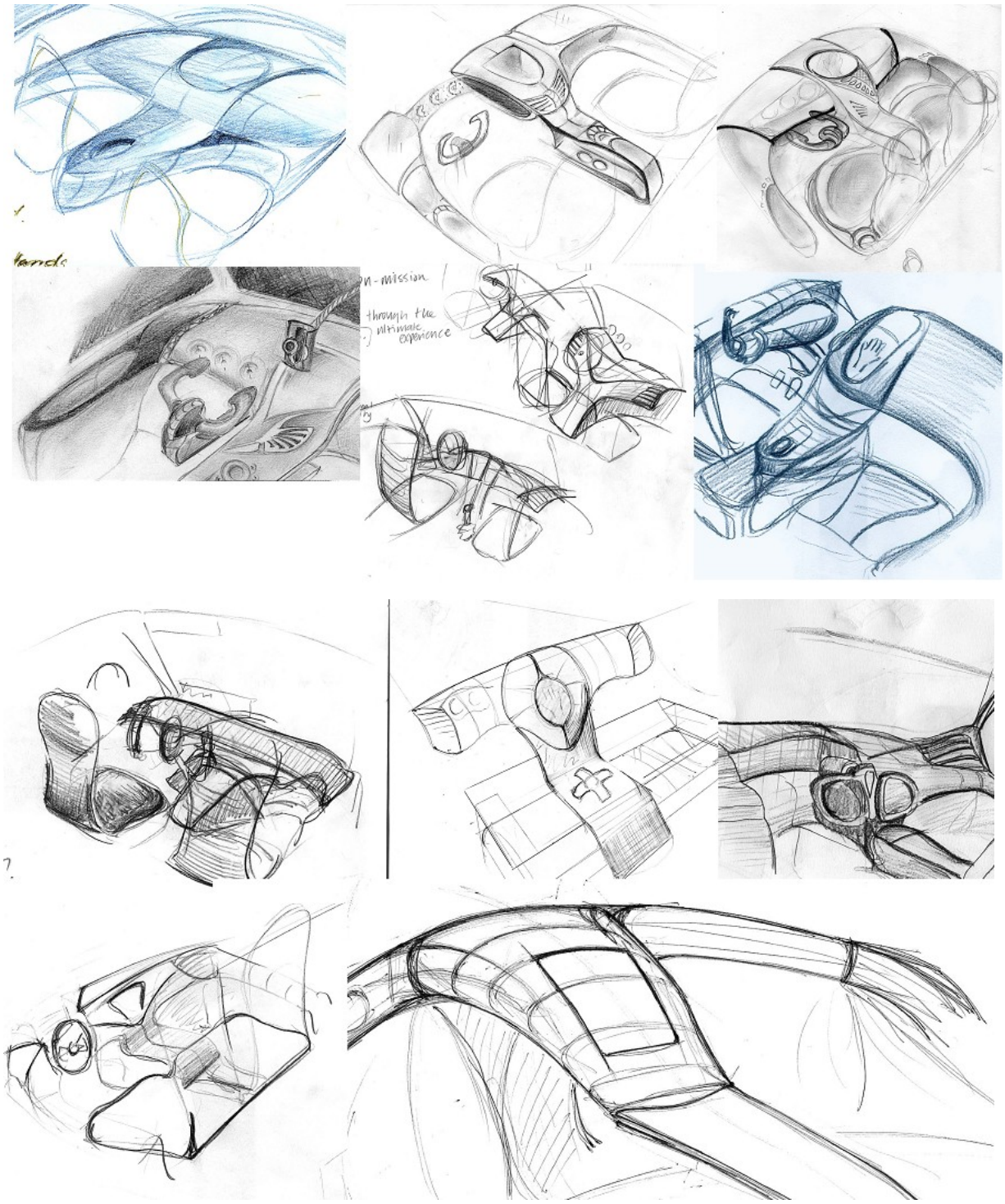


Figure 7, Sketches of Noyo Inside (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

6.3 Modelling the final product

Next, the concept was visualised in StudioTools where the shapes, colours and surface textures were determined. Images of the modelled product are presented in figure 8. As an example of innovative technological solutions, the steering hoop is a patented revolution (in this fictive story) of the classic steering wheel. Through a sensitive touch, the driver is in total

control of the car. The product also feels personal and comfortable. The product is not only physically emphasising the user's body with smooth lines and slim surfaces. It also creates a feeling of roominess with new materials that activate the sense of touch. The affective experience is further boosted by the specific use of light and colours, as well as sounds to create a pleasant environment. By adjusting the light and music, the user's mood will be reflected in the interior of the car. It creates a personal space, where the user feels safe and individual.

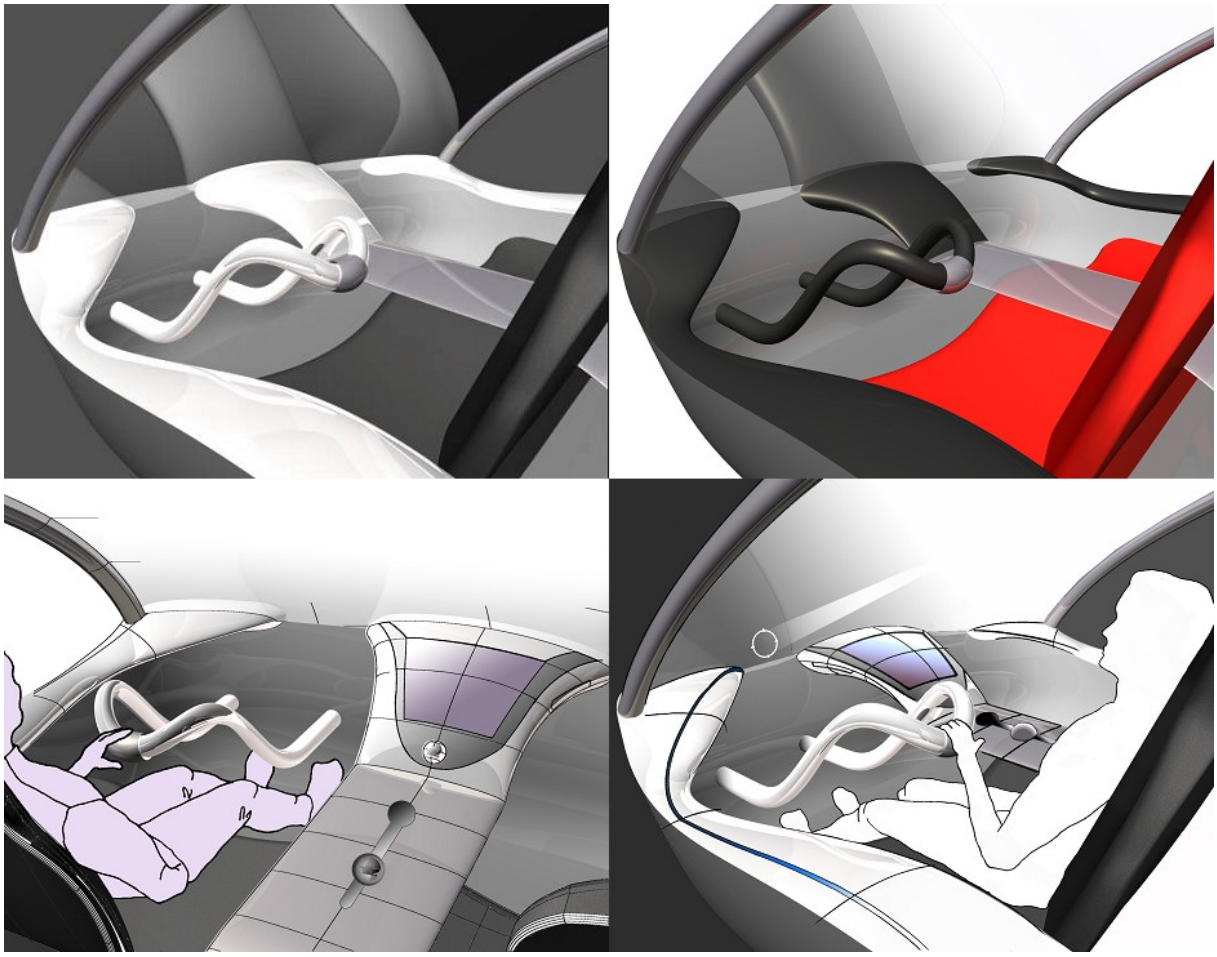


Figure 8, Models of Noyo Inside (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

In addition to the visualisations of the product, Noyo Inside included a wider service concept. Noyo Inside is a brand new concept of a car interior. It is designed with the personal experience of the customer (driver and passenger) as the priority. Almost everything can be adjusted to individual needs and wishes. The product also comes with unlimited services. Noyo has a large crew of employees, ready to help the customers with anything from finding the fastest way out of the traffic jam to finding the best sushi-restaurant in town. Noyo Inside

is a holistic interior and communication concept that is sold through licences to different car companies. Toyota is of course the first car brand to introduce the concept, but Noyo has already started negotiations with other brands that want to “have Noyo Inside”.

6.4 Design expressing the Noyo core values

The starting point for the visual appearance was to reflect the core values of Noyo. The personal experience is created with changeable lights, sounds and materials. This gives the product the feeling of “a second skin” and thus reinforces the personality aspect. The form language with smooth surfaces also gives a strong feeling of caring. Pure, wide, symmetric, and smooth surfaces provide feeling of harmony and friendliness. Opening up the front of the interior gives the user a feeling of space and closer interaction with the environment, which is common also in the Japanese house design. The heritage is also mirrored in the new product design, as pure and natural contrasting colours as well as transparent and glassy materials are used. In overall, the interior is made of less material than classical car interiors, signalling that Noyo is considering the environment. In summary, the Noyo Inside design cues are: the dividing line, light set, steering hoop, transparent materials, symmetry, and slim surfaces. Clear references to the inspiration boards and images were used when designing the concept, as figure 9 suggests.

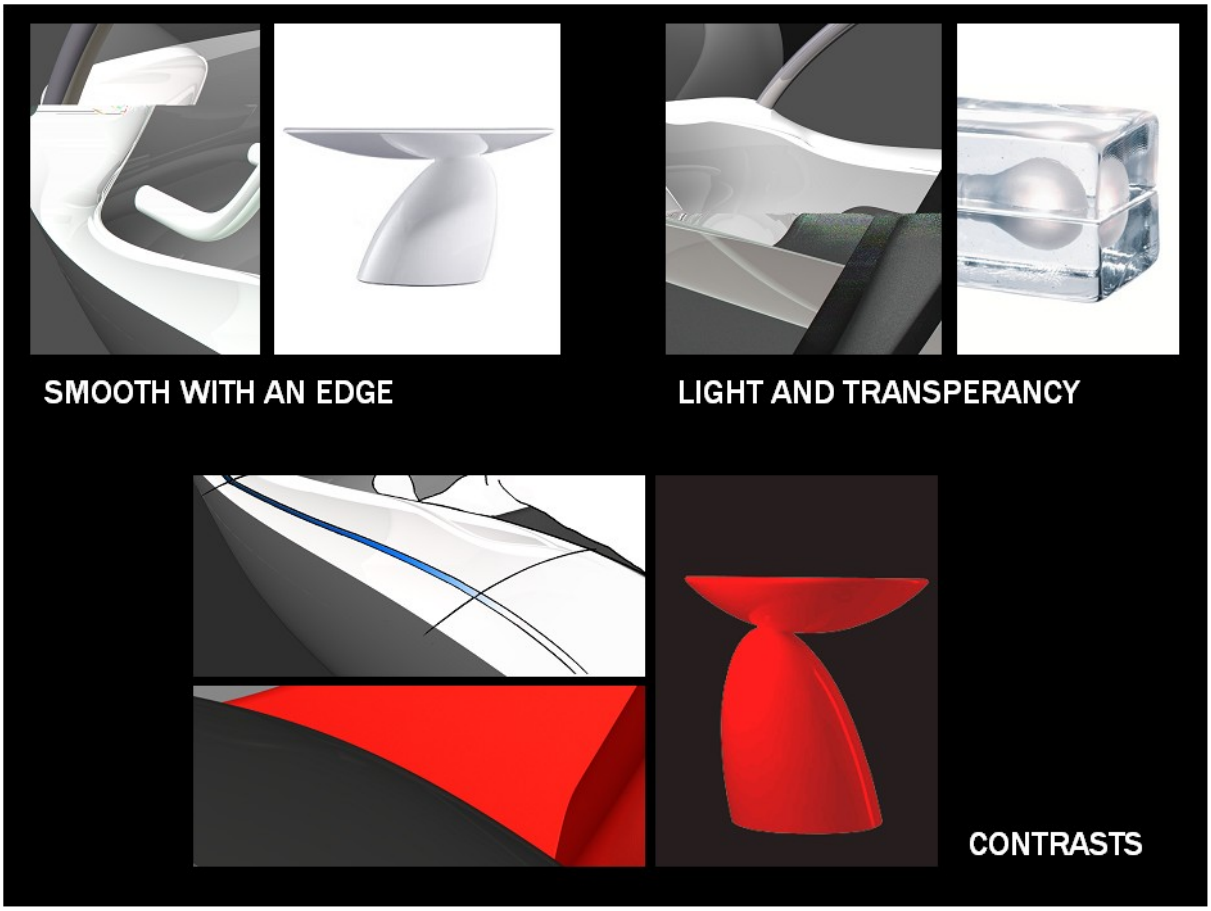


Figure 9, Details of Noyo Inside and their visual inspirations (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

7. Surprise and delight - presentation of the concept

In the project, presentations of the brands and new product concepts were also given high importance. Students were asked to present their ideas in a professional manner, as if they would be talking to an audience consisting of the brands' important stakeholders. This resulted in various means emphasising the affective dimension of the brands. Beautiful visualisations, videos, even music clips were created by students to accompany the factual and analytic presentations. Many of the presentations truly added emotional value to the brands and products concepts. In the Toyota-Nokia-Noyo case, the affective brand script was reinforced by presenting the process of brand creation and design process, as described in this paper, and adding lots of narrative components, such as use scenarios, to complement the logical story (see figure 10). In addition, clarity and professionalism were strongly present in the presentation, supported by the presenters' good use of voice and tone and the displayed combination of personality and expertise. In summary, the presentation was delightful and incorporated many surprising elements to keep the audience alert.

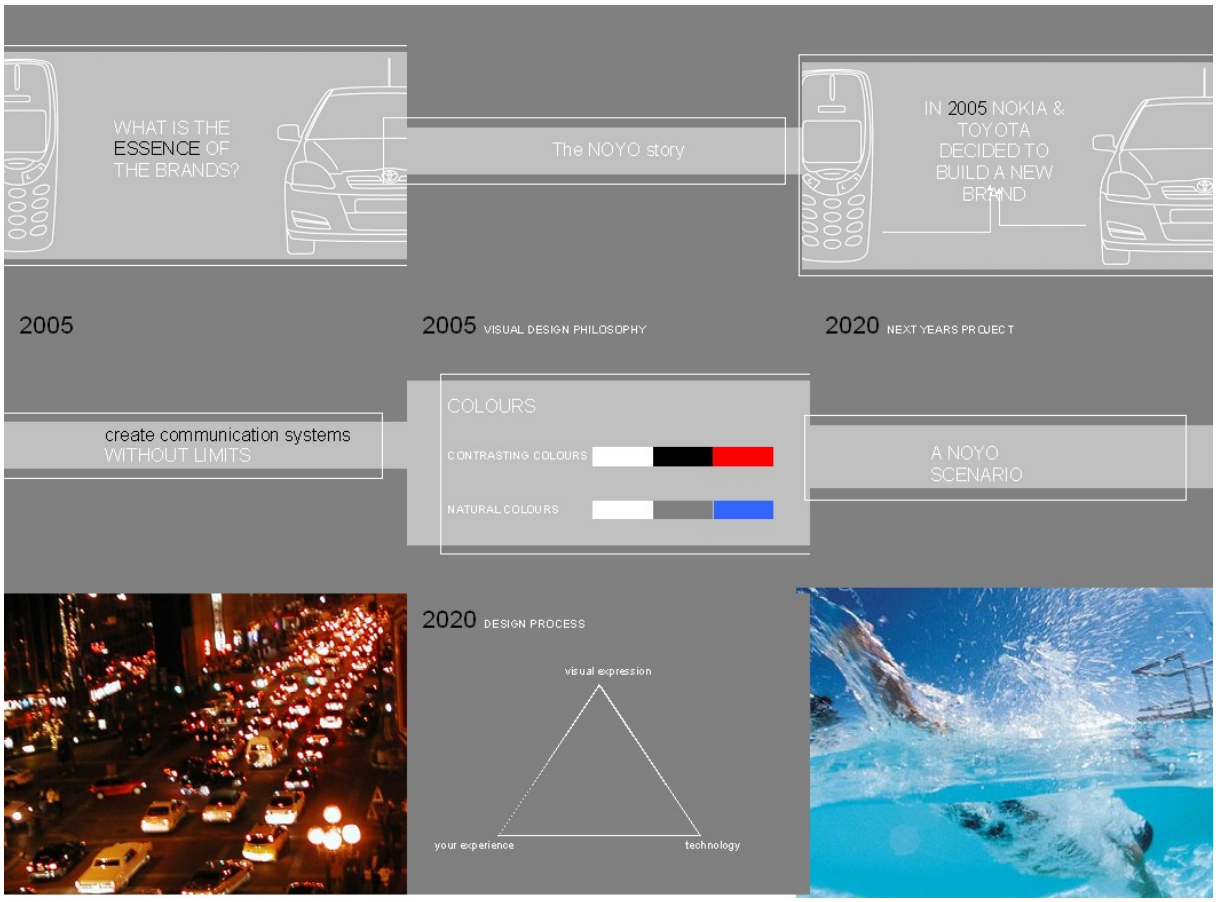


Figure 10, Snapshot of the Noyo presentation slides (created by Ljungman, Lodin & Starodub)

8. Concluding remarks

This case paper aimed to show how the processes of market analysis, brand creation, and building semantic references into design could be managed. The Noyo case, creation of a fictive brand and product, provided an insightful example of various issues that need to be taken into account when creating affective and appealing brand script and visual product identity. The case highlighted the importance of holistic approach towards creating affective brands and products. In addition to an excellent product, technically, cognitively and emotionally, appealing story is needed around it and the brand it represents. Most importantly, the essence of the brand needs to be clarified and nurtured. Then, the key challenge concerns the transformation of this essence into the visual and other product attributes.

The paper also presented the student project, as part of the "Visual brand identity and market analysis" course, as a potential approach towards learning the process of brand creation and visual recognition. There appear potential ways to dig deeper into the essence of the brands as

well as to the fundamentals of building visual recognition to products through various explicit and implicit references. Through knowledge concerning the semantic and emotional contents of different design features, created by such procedures, it is possible to manipulate the "character" of the product ─ thus to channel the user interpretation into a favourable direction. It should also be remembered that such knowledge is often case-specific. In terms of design education, therefore, approaches to enrich the emotional knowledge base of students are needed. This case paper presented a potential example of such sensitive approach.

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